

The Agricultural Workforce Working Group (the Working Group) met for the sixth time on 2 May 2023. The key focus areas for this meeting were:

- the role of migration in meeting the workforce needs of agriculture and processing sectors; and
- the housing needs of regional Australia, including the agriculture and processing sectors.

Members discussed the Migration Review and next steps and acknowledged the work of John Azarias and his fellow reviewers. Members welcomed the strong alignment between the Working Group's joint submission to the Migration Review and key components of the Outline of the Government's Migration Strategy, in particular:

- simplifying the visa and migration system to improve the experiences of people who interact with it
- improving the integrity of the migration system to prevent exploitation of migrant workers
- providing clear pathways to permanent residence for migrants
- supporting greater mobility of temporary migrants
- integrating and aligning migration with investments in infrastructure, service provision and housing.

Members also discussed opportunities to promote improved housing for agricultural and processing workers in regional areas, including hearing insights about the unique nature of the regional housing markets from Dr Kim Houghton, Chief Economist at the Regional Australia Institute.

Members acknowledged the work undertaken to date by the Government to relieve pressure on the housing market, including support for first home-owners, additional investment in social and affordable housing and the proposed creation of the Housing Australia Future Fund.

Members agreed to undertake further work on how to advocate for improved housing outcomes across all levels of government, noting each level has a significant role in delivering the housing Australia needs.

Members also noted the update on action items being progressed through sub-groups focused on skills, migration, worker protection, attracting Australians and inclusion.

The Working Group will next meet in June 2023.

Attendees

- Senator the Hon. Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- Tony Mahar, CEO, National Farmers' Federation
- Jannette Armstrong, Executive Director - Farms, United Workers Union
- George Robertson, National Coordinator for Farms, United Workers Union
- Shane Roulstone, National Organising Director, Australian Workers' Union
- Patrick Hutchinson, CEO, Australian Meat Industry Council
- Matt Journeaux, Federal Secretary, Australasian Meat Industry Employees Union
- Richard Shannon, Executive Officer, NFF Horticulture Council

- Michele Lawrence, Member, People and Communities Policy Advisory Group, Australian Dairy Farmers
- Andrew Metcalfe AO, Secretary, Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- James Flintoft, Independent Facilitator
- John Azarias, Special Advisor to the Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry on Agricultural Workforce Issues

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/ag-workforce-working-group-may-2023>